

interoperabilitybridges.com for more.) Already, the majority of Eclipse users are doing their development on the Windows platform—the annual Eclipse survey stands as a testimony to this fact.

Another area that we aim to address is the issue of disparate approaches adopted by developers. For example, PHP developers are mostly working in silos. Every PHP developer has a different answer for any given problem. And the reason is that they use different development tools, and thus each has a different outlook when it comes to solving problems. If some people use PDT (PHP development tools), others use finished PHP applications, like WordPress.

Q Currently, which are the open source projects being supported by Microsoft?

Microsoft is working closely with various open source communities, such as the PHP, Apache, and Linux communities. The company has also been a platinum sponsor of the Apache Software Foundation since 2008. We have made numerous contributions to various open source projects in the last one year, which include:

- Engagement with the Eclipse Foundation in modernising Eclipse on Windows
- Windows Azure Platform SDKs and tools for open source developers
- Device driver code for Linux, which enables better performance of Linux when virtualised with Windows Server Hyper-V
- Hyper-V Linux Integration Components that make managing heterogeneous systems easier
- WordPress plug-in (Bing + Azure), which allows Web developers to add cool Microsoft features on top of the LAMP stack
- CoApp, which makes it easy for developers to run Linux applications on Windows, opening up more opportunities for broad adoption of their applications

If you go to infobridge.com, you will see close to 40 different projects. Of these, 12 or 13 are specific to Windows Azure. In Windows Azure, we have also articulated the application fabric, allowing those applications to be released as open source apps. About 10 of these projects will continue to grow.

We haven't set any artificial numbers, but have a strong strategy, particularly to empower non-Microsoft users, and provide them with rich set-up tools, so that they can leverage their existing skills.

Q What is your take on PHP?

I think PHP is one of the top platforms, currently. There are a large number of Web applications today that run on PHP. Considering this, Microsoft is working with the *PHP.net* open source community, and with Zend (the commercial PHP company), to ensure that applications

written in PHP work well with Windows Server and SQL Server. Thus, the focus on PHP is pretty strong—but we will also continue to focus on Java, JSP (Java Server Pages), and others.

Q With the onset of the SaaS and cloud era, do you think open source would matter to an end user? What are your views on it?

When it comes to open source and the cloud, I want to share a great example. SugarCRM is a 100 per cent open source company, which has chosen to offer its online (cloud-based) services on Microsoft's Azure platform. The CEO, Larry Augustin, was part of the group that coined the term 'open source'. When the cloud computing phenomenon started to take hold, SugarCRM began its search for the best cloud platform to help extend its business to the cloud, and to help it pursue the new business opportunities presented by this trend. Its choice was Microsoft, and it became one of our first customers on Windows Azure.

This example helps make a critical point in our discussion of openness on the cloud. In truth, what we've learned over the years and what is becoming even more apparent now in the cloud realm is that it doesn't really matter whether the platform is open or closed. What matters is that technology enables reliable and seamless delivery of services to the customer. The focus for all of us in the technology industry, at the end of the day, has to be on working together to deliver the best solutions for our customers.

Q In the ERP and CRM space, there are certain open source projects available and running. Would you be putting them also on the Azure platform?

Open source projects on CRM can work well on the Azure platform too. Besides, a growing number of open source companies are becoming Microsoft partners, such as Zend, SugarCRM, Network Earth and Bitrix, and are offering open source solutions on Microsoft platforms to their customers. But we don't want to dictate that these applications should be running only on Azure.

Q Are you only focused on the Windows Azure platform, or looking at the overall open source scenario?

It is the overall scenario that interests us. Though we do have a long-term plan in place, ultimately, being a commercial organisation, we are focusing on a two-year horizon. This year, our focus is on cloud computing (i.e., Windows Azure SDK); mobile platforms is another area—with the release of the Windows Phone 7 series, we want to make sure that there is excitement in the community, and that they develop applications for it. Whether you use Android development, iPhone, or any open source mobile tool, we want developers to think about an open cloud platform, where you could